



**MASTERMIND
INDIA**
Spirit of India Special

SOAK AND AWE

**Remya
JOSE, 21**

INNOVATION

**A mechanical
washing machine**

COST

Rs 2,000

WHAT IT DOES

**Washes clothes using
a pedalling system
which does not
require electricity**

It was a challenging time for Remya Jose. Her Class X examinations were on and she had to keep up her brilliant academic record. Her father, Joseph, a schoolteacher, was undergoing treatment for cancer. Her mother Marykutty, also a schoolteacher, had fallen ill. All the domestic chores fell on her and her twin sister Soumya. The sisters realised that they hardly had enough time to devote to their studies. This was when Jose decided to make a washing machine. But as the power supply in her small village of Keezhattur in Malappuram district was erratic, she did not want to make an electrical machine.

She drew a diagram of a mechanical washing machine. With help from workers of a nearby auto workshop, she made the machine during her vacation. The contraption consisted of an aluminium cabin which had a horizontal cylinder made of iron net wire. The cylinder was connected to a pedalling system resembling an exercise cycle. Clothes were put in the cylinder, the cabin was filled with water as well as washing powder and left to soak for 10 minutes. The next step was pedalling the cycle for three or four

minutes to rotate the cylinder at a high speed with the clothes inside. The rotating cylinder would rinse and clean the clothes thoroughly after which the soap water would be allowed to drain. The cabin would be refilled and the process repeated. The clothes would be washed and dried in 20 minutes and, in the process, the operator would shed a few kilos as a special bonus. "Wash your clothes cheap and keep physically fit too in the process. All at a cost of Rs 2,000," says Jose, an engineering graduate now.

In 2003, with support from National Innovation Foundation (NIF), she became the proud owner of a national patent for her machine. In 2005, her innovation was judged the best among 25,000 competitors at the NIF's Third National Grassroots Technological Innovations and Traditional Knowledge competition.

**DESPITE HER
INVENTION GETTING
MUCH ACCLAIM,
JOSE'S WASHING
MACHINE HAS NOT
FOUND A MARKET.**

Ironically, it has not brought Jose any cheer. Though she received much acclaim for her invention, there weren't many takers for it as it wasn't considered commercially viable. She has gone to the UAE now with her uncle to look for a job. Showing the bundle of certificates and prizes Jose has won during her student days for various innovations, her father Joseph laments; "What's the use of all this if she cannot find a decent job in her country?" India needs to answer this disappointed father.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan



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JOSE WITH HER
MECHANICAL
WASHING MACHINE